

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 10 5 4
♥ J 5
♦ 9 6
♣ K 9 7 5 2

♠ Q 7 3
♥ A Q 6 4 3
♦ 8 5 2
♣ A J



♠ K J 9
♥ 10 2
♦ K 7 4 3
♣ Q 10 6 4

♠ 8 6 2
♥ K 9 8 7
♦ A Q J 10
♣ 8 3

West	North	East	South
	1♥	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North

You are wide open in ♠s, so you have to hope that East holds the ♦K. But that won't be enough by itself, in case he has ♦K x x x you also have to have three entries to your hand. Two of them will be the ♥A and ♥Q and the third entry must be the ♣A.

So you win the first trick with the ♣A and immediately take your first ♦finesse. It wins, so you return to your hand with a ♥ to the ♥Q and take another ♦finesse. Back to your hand with the ♥A (pulling the last trumps) and take a third ♦finesse. Finally on the ♦A you can discard either your ♣ loser or a ♠. You will have to give up three tricks at the end.

This plan would work 50% of the time, whenever East was dealt the ♦K.

Any other plan that was based on East holding the ♦K would work **ALMOST** 50% of the time but would fail when East had three protectors for the ♦K.

You open 1♥, partner responds 3♥.

What is your next bid?

Partner's 3♥ response shows 11-12 points with good trumps.

With your 14 points you decide to bid the game.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♣4, West plays the ♣K.

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Losers: ♠ 3 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 1 : Total = 6

There is no hope of extra winners except the ♦ suit.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 8

♥ 9 4

♦ A 6 3 2

♣ 10 9 6

♠ K 7 3

♥ A 8 6 2

♦ Q 4

♣ Q 7 5 4



♠ 9 6 5

♥ K 7

♦ 10 9 8 5

♣ K J 8 2

♠ A 4 2

♥ Q J 10 5 3

♦ K J 7

♣ A 3

West

North

East

South

Pass

3♥

Pass

1♥

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by South

you should try to find somewhere to put the ♠ loser.

You have 11 (perhaps 12) points and four trumps.
Just right for a limit raise.

So you bid 3♥ and partner goes to game.

North would play 4♥.

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South plays 4♥. West leads the ♠Q.

South plays 4♥. West leads the ♠Q.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

You know you can't get rid of the ♦ loser, and it's hard to imagine a way that would let you get rid of the ♣ loser. The ♥ loser depends on the finesse. So

First you win the ♠A. You know that you will eventually take the ♥ finesse, so should you take it now? Visualize the likely defense actions if you do. Say East wins the ♥K. He will surely play another ♠, knocking out dummy's ♠K. Whenever you try to set up ♦s the defense will take their ♠ trick and you will eventually go down.

What happened is that you gave the defense a tempo and let them control the timing of the play. You should not have rushed into the ♥ finesse. Instead suppose that you win the first trick with dummy's ♠K and immediately play the ♦Q. The defense can take their ♦A when they want to and push another ♠, but now the timing is on your side. You can discard a ♠ from dummy on your good ♦ in time.

Take the ♥ finesse before you set up a ♦ trick and you will be just fine if the finesse wins. But if it loses you will lose a tempo and the defense will get to your ♠ loser before you can set up a ♦.

Set up the ♦ winner before you take the ♥ finesse and you will always be able to dump the ♠ loser no matter who has the ♥K.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 8 6 5
♥ 9 7 3
♦ Q 10 6 3
♣ A 9 2

♠ A J 9 3

♥ K 8 2

♦ A 8

♣ Q J 5 3



♠ K 7 2

♥ 10 5 4

♦ K J 9 2

♣ 7 6 4

♠ Q 10 4

♥ A Q J 6

♦ 7 5 4

♣ K 10 8

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 4 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 0 : Total = 6

With 15 points and a balanced hand of course you open 1NT.

Partner's response is 2♣.

Partner's 2♣ bid is Stayman asking you to name a 4-card Major.

You bid 2♠, but that must not have been the Major he wanted so he bids 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♦ 2. West plays ♦ Q. You hold up on this trick and West returns the ♦ 3.

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You need to get three more winners and you have two very clear possibilities.

If West holds the ♠ K you can finesse him out of it and win an additional 3 tricks in the suit. The problem with this approach is that half the time East will hold the ♠ K and you will go down.

Or you can drive out the ♣ A and definitely set up an additional 3 tricks in that suit. The problem with this approach is that if the defender's ♦ s split 5-3 they will be able to win 4 ♦ s and the ♣ A.

If you pay attention to the opening lead this becomes a simple decision. East led the ♦ 2. Assuming that was fourth down then he must have led from a 4-card suit. So it looks like the ♦ s must be splitting 4-4 and it is safe for you to establish ♣ s. So you drive out the ♣ A. The defenders take their other 2 ♦ s but you make the game losing only 3 ♦ s and the ♣ A.

In this layout the ♠ finesse fails, as it would do half the time.

East's lead of the ♦ 2 should have made you pretty sure that he had led from a 4-card suit. If the ♦ 2 is fourth down, there cannot be a fifth down. Additionally, West's return of the ♦ 3 confirmed that conclusion. If West had started with only 3 ♦ s, (say ♦ Q 6 3) his correct return at trick 2 would have been his next highest, the ♦ 6. With 4 cards in the suit his correct return is his original fourth down.